WHAT HAS ADDED TO THE RESENTMENT AGAINST THE CENTRE IS THAT PM MODI HAS NOT VISITED MANIPUR IN THE PAST 16 MONTHS

Union of Manipur against a single-judge order from the Manipur High Court, since withdrawn, that recommended Scheduled Tribe (ST) status for Meiteis. A contentious issue for decades, the status would free the Meiteis from a long-held sense of geographical containment: the Imphal Valley covers just 11 per cent of Manipur's land, but houses 53 per cent of its total population. The Meiteis, 44 per cent of the population, dominates politically, controlling 40 out of 60 assembly seats, but as non-tribals find themselves debarred from buying land in the autonomously administered hill districts. Home the Nagas (24 per cent) and Kuki-Zos (16 per cent), who have historically alleged political marginalisation, the hill districts cover 89 per cent of Manipur's area. The spatial skew lessens considerably against the fact that 78 per cent of Manipur is forest—a mix of dense, moderate and open, the last two segments becoming natural candidates to soak up the demographic pressure.

Meiteis have suggested a broader political conspiracy, noting that violence erupted shortly after Mizoram chief minister Lalduhoma's remarks in the US advocating for a "Christian nation" for Kuki-Zos by consolidating its populations in India, Myanmar and Bangladesh. Meitei groups say this prompted cross-border Kuki groups to seize land. The dissenters cite the ongoing civil war in Myanmar, its attendant refugee influx flowing overwhelmingly into Mizoram with a much smaller spillover into Manipur.

The question looms ever larger: how to break this cycle of violence? The answer lies in the political will to addressing deep-rooted issues of representation, resources and ethnic identity. ■

OMAR FACES A QUOTA CHALLENGE

By Kaleem Geelani

Just over a month into its tenure, the Omar Abdullah government is seeking to meet head-on one of the toughest challenges it faces: acting on its poll promise to revisit Jammu & Kashmir's reservation policy. As Omar resumes the chief minister's job after a gap of nearly a decade, he confronts record levels of unemployment. Job aspirants far outnumber available government or private sector jobs—a scenario that adds a sharp edge to the call to reverse or scale down reservations, especially those initiated by the Lieutenant Governor-led administration earlier this year. The CM, facing heat for weeks, finally acted at a cabinet meeting on November 22—forming a sub-committee of three ministers to examine the issue.

The present quotas in J&K add up to a staggering 60 per cent and cast a shadow over the government's poll promise of generating one lakh jobs and the filling of all state sector vacancies within 180 days of its formation. "Our youth, especially those in the open category, feel they are not getting their rights. At the same time, those in the ambit of reservation do not want to see curtailment in their rights," Omar has said cautiously.

Under the LG's' administration since 2019, the state-turned-Union territory has seen a revision of its job reservation policy as the BJP-led Centre set out to woo tribals and those belonging to Other Backward Classes (OBCs). In March 2024, the administration made amendments to Jammu Kashmir Reservation Rules, 2005, to allocate 10 per cent more reservation to four communities—Paharis, Paddaris, Kolis and Gadda Brahmins—newly inducted into the Scheduled Tribes (ST) category, in addition to the existing 10 per

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PRESSURE TO ACT CM Omar Abdullah in the Jammu & Kashmir assembly